Convicted for sedition, VOC had lost his pleadership *sanad*. Rather than return to his hometown—in any case all his assets and savings had been wiped out during his time in prison—he moved to Madras City doing odd things. After eight years in the presidency capital, in 1920, he went to Coimbatore to work as a clerk. It was only in 1924 that he regained his pleadership certificate—ironically, at the instance of E.H. Wallace, the magistrate who had committed him in the sedition trial. Even though he considered resuming practice in Tuticorin, curiously, he moved to Kovilpatti, a town some fifty kilometres away. His income was less than modest.

Though he was referred to popularly as 'V.O. Chidambaram Pillai of Tuticorin', in fact, it was a quarter of a century after the glorious Swadeshi days that VOC relocated to Tuticorin. So deeply intertwined was the town to his life. It was only in 1932, having turned sixty, and in failing health, that VOC returned to the port town. One can only speculate why he delayed the return to his old haunt. Perhaps the memories of the Swadeshi days haunted him. The slide from affluence to penury may have hurt his pride and the family's reputation. A man of honour, he may have been embarrassed to face the investors who had backed him in the ill-fated enterprise.

In his death, VOC laid bare the fault lines in Tamil society. The obituaries and tributes that poured in show the various ideological forces that tried to appropriate his legacy. But in sum, the image that stuck was of a courageous and unflinching idealist who heroically sacrificed his all but never received his due.

VOC himself hardly ever talked of his achievements. As we saw, in his verse autobiography, VOC provided only a terse account of his role in the shipping company. But even this narrative saw light of day only after his death. His memoir of Bharati that contains stray references to the shipping company was also not published in his lifetime. Despite living a full twenty-four years after his release from prison and publishing extensively rarely did he speak of his great achievement. Was it modesty? Was it disappointment? Was he scarred by an experiment that devastated his life